

I H A T E T O B D G E T

User Guide & Manual

*A simple web app to understand and control your expenses
Designed to be self-hosted*

Version 2.0

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1. Executive Summary

IHateToBudget is a lightweight, self-hosted web application designed to help individuals and households understand and manage their personal finances. This user guide and manual provide comprehensive guidance on installing, configuring, and using the application effectively.

This document follows ISO/IEC/IEEE 26514:2008 standards for professional software documentation and includes:

- Step-by-step installation and configuration procedures
- Getting started guidance for new users.
- Detailed feature walkthroughs with supporting figures.
- Best practices for managing financial data securely and efficiently.
- Troubleshooting guidance and solutions to common issues.
- Technical reference materials and appendices.

1. Introduction & Overview

1.1 Purpose & Vision

IHateToBudget was developed to address a fundamental need: providing individuals with a simple, efficient tool to track and analyse personal expenses. Unlike commercial alternatives, this application emphasizes:

- **Data Privacy:** Self-hosted, no data shared with third parties
- **Simplicity:** Intuitive interface focused on core functionality
- **Accessibility:** Can be deployed on minimal hardware (e.g., Raspberry Pi)
- **Open Source:** Community-driven development and transparency

1.2 Key Features

The application provides the following core features:

- **Category Management** – Create and manage custom expense categories with distinct colours for improved organization and visualization.
- **Expense Tracking** – Record daily expenses with dates, categories, amounts, descriptions, and optional receipt attachments. Expenses are automatically organized by month.
- **Statistical Analytics** – View interactive charts and summaries that visualize spending patterns, category distributions, and monthly expenditure trends.
- **Budget Management (New in v2.0.0)** – Set monthly spending limits for each expense category and monitor real-time budget utilization.
- **Receipt Uploads (New in v2.0.0)** – Attach digital receipts (JPG, PNG, or PDF) to expense records for secure and organized record-keeping.
- **Data Export (New in v2.0.0)** – Export personal financial records in CSV format for backup, reporting, or external analysis.
- **Dark Mode (New in v2.0.0)** – Switch between light and dark themes to improve accessibility and user comfort. Theme preferences are automatically saved for future sessions.
- **Multi-User Support (New in v2.0.0)** – Register and manage individual user accounts with secure authentication and user-specific data isolation, ensuring each user's financial records remain private.

1.3 Technology Stack

IHateToBudget is built using modern web technologies:

Component	Technology	Purpose
Backend	Django (Python)	Web application framework
Frontend	HTML/CSS/JavaScript	User interface rendering
Database	SQLite (Default)	Persistent data storage
Deployment	Docker/Docker Compose	Containerization & orchestration

2. System Requirements

2.1 Hardware Requirements

IHateToBudget is designed to run on minimal hardware. The following are recommended specifications:

Resource	Minimum	Recommended
Processor	ARM v7 (Raspberry Pi)	Multi-core x86/ARM
RAM	512 MB	2 GB+
Storage	500 MB	2 GB+
Network	Ethernet or WiFi	Gigabit Ethernet

2.2 Software Requirements

The following software components must be installed on your system:

- Docker (version 19.03 or later)
- Docker Compose (version 1.25.0 or later)
- Git (optional, for cloning the repository)
- Web browser with JavaScript support (modern versions of Chrome, Firefox, Safari, or Edge)

2.3 Network Requirements

The application requires:

- TCP Port 80 (HTTP) - available and not blocked by firewall
- Local network access from client devices

3. Installation & Initial Setup

3.1 Pre-Installation Checklist

Before installing IHateToBudget, ensure the following prerequisites are met:

- Docker and Docker Compose are installed and running
- Port 80 is available on your host system
- Git is installed (optional, for repository cloning)
- Sufficient disk space for application and database files

3.2 Installation Overview

Follow these steps to install and start using IHateToBudget on your system.

Step 1: Install Docker

First, you need to install Docker and Docker Compose on your computer.

On Linux (Ubuntu/Debian):

Open a terminal and run these commands:

```
sudo apt-get update
sudo apt-get install docker.io docker-compose
sudo usermod -aG docker $USER
```

On Windows or Mac:

Download and install Docker Desktop from docker.com. This includes both Docker and Docker Compose together.

Step 2: Download IHateToBudget

Download the IHateToBudget code using Git. Open your terminal or command prompt and run:

```
git clone https://github.com/bminus1/ihatetobudget.git
cd ihatetobudget
```

This creates a folder called "ihatetobudget" and navigates into it.

Step 3: Start the Application

While still in the ihatetobudget folder, run:

```
docker-compose up -d
```

This downloads and starts IHateToBudget in the background. The first time may take a few minutes.

Step 4: Create Your First Account

Once the application is running, open your web browser and go to:

`http://127.0.0.1`

You'll see a setup screen. Follow the instructions to create your username and password. That's it—you're ready to start!

Accessing From Other Computers

If you want to access IHateToBudget from another computer on your home network, instead of `http://127.0.0.1`, use your server's IP address. For example:

`http://192.168.1.100`

Stopping IHateToBudget

To stop the application, open a terminal in the `ihatetobudget` folder and type: `docker-compose down`

4. Getting Started

4.1 Self-Service Registration

Unlike legacy versions requiring administrator account creation, v2.0.0 supports secure self-service onboarding as illustrated in Figure 1.

I H A T E T O
BUDGET

Register Sign in

Create account

Username

Required. 150 characters or fewer. Letters, digits and @/./+/-/_ only.

Email

Password

- Your password can't be too similar to your other personal information.
- Your password must contain at least 8 characters.
- Your password can't be a commonly used password.
- Your password can't be entirely numeric.

Password confirmation

Enter the same password as before, for verification.

Register

Powered By IHateToBudget

Version 1.5.7

Figure 1: Registration Page

Steps:

1. On the landing page, click the "Register" button
2. Complete the registration form:
 - Username: Choose a unique identifier
 - Email: Valid email address (for password recovery in future releases)
 - Password: Must meet complexity requirements:
 - Minimum 8 characters
 - Contains uppercase and lowercase letters
 - Contains at least one digit
 - Contains at least one special character

3. Click "Create Account"
4. You will be automatically logged in and redirected to your personal dashboard

4.2 User Login

Returning users can securely access their individual accounts by providing their credentials on the login page, which is shown in Figure 2.

The screenshot shows the 'Sign in' page of the IHateToBudget application. At the top, there is a navigation bar with the application logo 'IHATE TO BUDGET' on the left, and links for 'Register' and 'Sign in' on the right. The main heading 'Sign in' is centered above a white login form. The form contains two input fields: 'Username' and 'Password'. Below these fields is a prominent blue button labeled 'Sign In'. Underneath the button, there is a link that reads 'Don't have an account? Host your own instance of IHateToBudget.' The footer of the page includes the text 'Powered By IHateToBudget' on the left and 'Version 1.5.7' on the right.

Figure 2: Login Page

1. Navigate to the application URL
2. On the landing page, click the "Login" button
3. Enter your credentials:
 - **Username:** Your registered username
 - **Password:** Your account password
4. Click "Log In"
5. You will be redirected to your personal dashboard

4.3 Dashboard Overview

Upon successful authentication, users are redirected to the main dashboard, which provides a high-level summary of financial status and quick-access navigation as depicted in Figure 3.

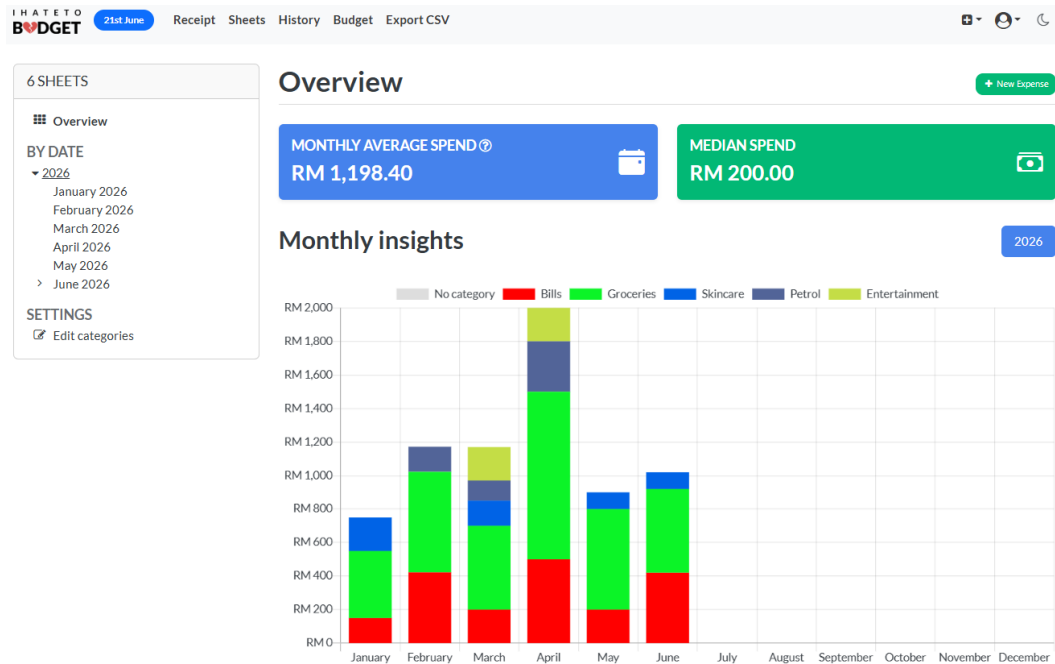


Figure 3: Application Dashboard

Navigation Menu (Left Sidebar):

- Categories - Manage expense categories
- Sheet - View and add monthly expenses
- Budget - Set and monitor budget limits (New in v2.0.0)
- Overview - View statistical analytics
- History - Search and filter all transactions

Top Navigation Bar:

User Profile - Access account settings

- Export CSV - Download your financial data (New in v2.0.0)
- Toggle Theme - Switch between light and dark modes (New in v2.0.0)
- Logout - Securely end your session

Main Content Area:

- Current month's expense summary
- Quick statistics
- Recent transactions

4.4 First Steps

We recommend the following sequence when first using the application:

Step 1: Define Categories

Navigate to the Categories section and create custom expense categories relevant to your spending patterns.

- Click 'Add Category'
- Enter category name (e.g., 'Groceries', 'Transport', 'Entertainment')
- Select a colour for visual identification

Step 2: Set Budget Limits (New in v2.0.0)

Configure monthly spending limits to track your financial goals.

- Navigate to **Budget** section
- Click '**Set New Budget Limit**'
- Select a category and enter your limit amount
- Click '**Save**'

Step 3: Add Initial Expenses

Add your first expense entry to become familiar with the data entry process.

- Navigate to the **main dashboard** view
- Click '**Add Expense**'
- Enter date, category, amount, and optional description
- Upload receipt if available
- Click '**Save**'

Step 4: Review Overview

- Use the sidebar navigation to select the specific month you wish to review.
- Navigate to the Overview section to visualize your spending patterns, category distributions, and monthly trends.

5. Feature Walkthrough

5.1 Categories Section

The Categories interface allows for the granular management of expense groupings, including color-coded visualization for better tracking, as displayed in Figure 4.

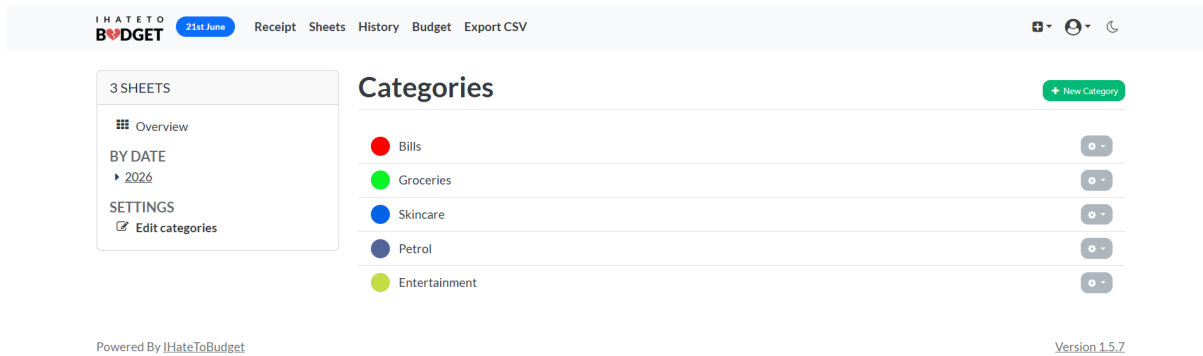


Figure 4: Categories Management Interface

5.2 Creating Categories

Creating Categories

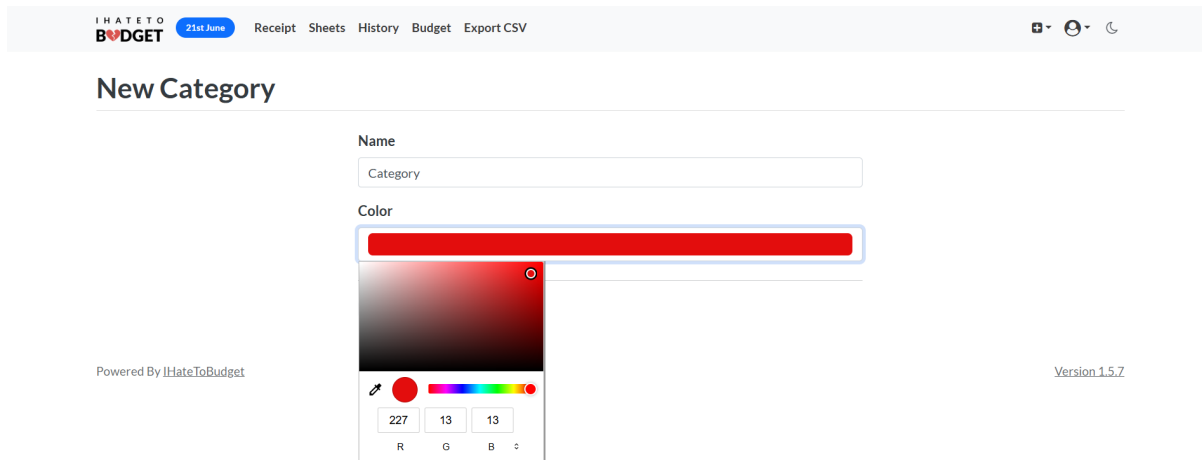


Figure 5: Creating Categories Page

To create a new category, follow the steps in the interface shown in Figure 5:

1. Click the **'New Category'** button
2. Enter a descriptive category name
3. Click on the colour picker and select a distinctive colour. Colour values must be entered in hexadecimal format (e.g., #FFFFFF).
4. Click **'Save'** to confirm

Editing Categories

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Figure 6: Editing Categories Page

To modify an existing category, follow the steps in the interface shown in Figure 6:

1. Click the **'Edit'** icon next to the category
2. Update category name or colour as needed
3. Click **'Save'** to apply changes

Deleting Categories

Powered By [IHateToBudget](#) [Version 1.5.7](#)

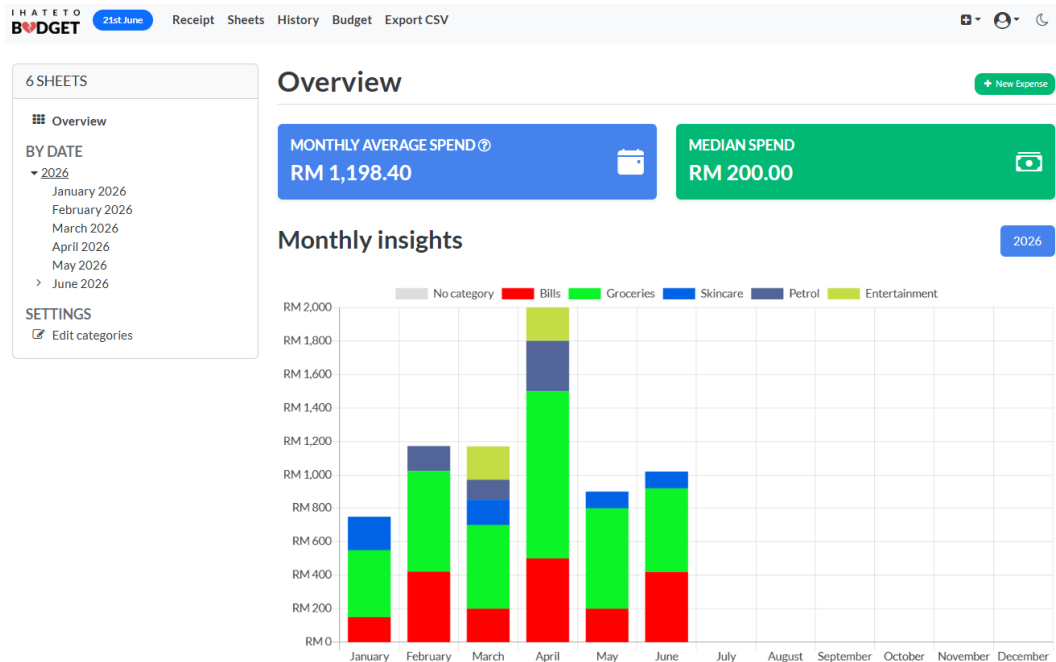
Figure 7: Deleting Categories Page

To delete an existing category, follow the steps in the interface shown in Figure 7:

- Click the **'Delete'** icon next to the category
- Confirm deletion (Note: Categories with existing expenses will turn to N/A)

5.2 Expenses View - Monthly Expense Entry

The main dashboard provides the primary interface for entering and managing expenses. Expenses are automatically organized by month.



New Expense

The 'New Expense' form is displayed with the following details:

- User:** Yousef
- Category:** Bills
- Date:** 2026-01-25
- Description:** #20 Description
- Amount:** 150
- Receipt:** Receipt1.pdf
- ☐ **Repeat next month?**
If checked, this expense will be automatically duplicated at the start of next month. This is particularly useful for monthly subscriptions.
- Buttons:** Cancel, Save

Figure 8: Adding Expenses Page

Adding Expenses

1. Click **'New Expense'** button as shown in Figure 8
2. Select the expense date using the date picker

3. Choose the appropriate category from dropdown
4. Enter an optional description (e.g., "Tesco - weekly groceries")
5. Enter the expense amount
6. **Upload Receipt:**
 - Click 'Choose File'
 - Select image (JPG, PNG) or PDF receipt from your device
 - File will be securely stored and linked to this expense
7. Click 'Save'

Editing & Deleting Expenses

Users can manage existing transaction records using the tools shown in Figure 9.

Expense History 23 Expenses

Type a date, category, amount or description 🔍

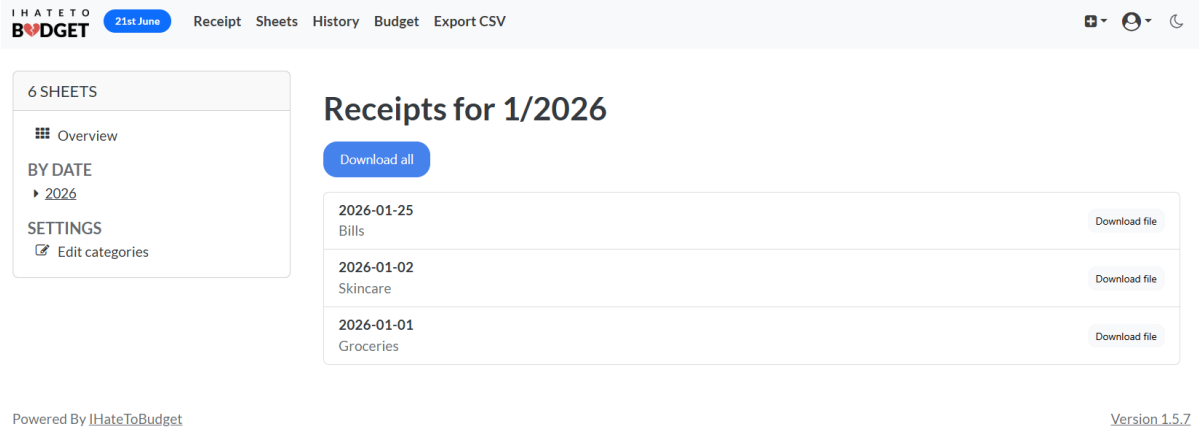
DATE	CATEGORY	AMOUNT	DESCRIPTION	ACTIONS
2026-06-21	Groceries	RM 500.00	#1 Description	⋮
2026-06-21	Skincare	RM 100.00	#2 Description	⋮
2026-06-21	Bills	RM 300.00	#3 Description	⋮
2026-06-21	Bills	RM 120.00	#4 Description	⋮
2026-05-21	Bills	RM 200.00	#5 Description	⋮
2026-05-21	Skincare	RM 100.00	#6 Description	⋮
2026-05-21	Groceries	RM 600.00	#7 Description	⋮
2026-04-21	Bills	RM 500.00	#8 Description	⋮
2026-04-21	Petrol	RM 300.00	#8 Description	⋮
2026-04-21	Groceries	RM 1,000.00	#9 Description	⋮
2026-04-21	Entertainment	RM 200.00	#9 Description	⋮
2026-03-21	Bills	RM 200.00	#10 Description	⋮

Figure 9: Editing & Deleting Expenses Page

1. Click on any expense row to open the edit dialog
2. Modify any field as needed
3. Update receipt if necessary
4. Click **'Save'** to apply changes or **'Delete'** to remove expense

Downloading Receipts

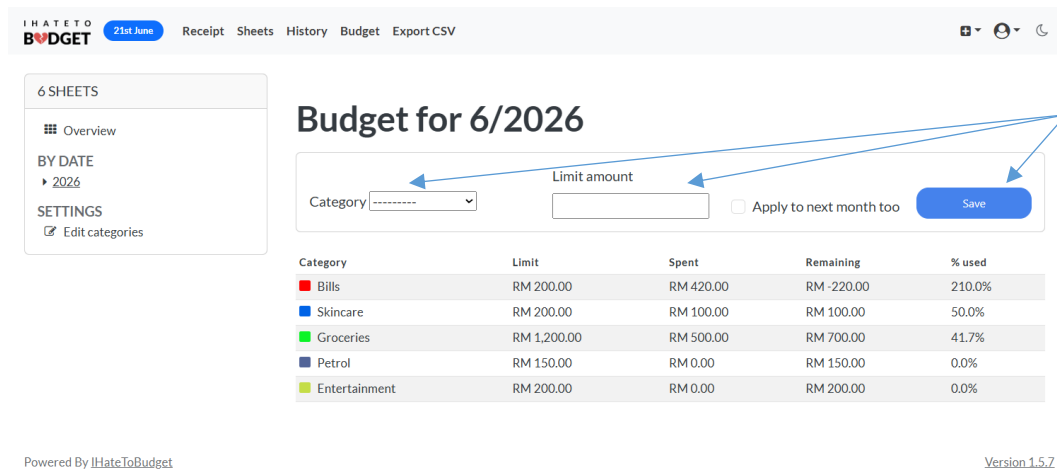
Receipts can be retrieved and downloaded via the interface demonstrated in Figure 10.



- Click Receipts in the navigation bar on the main dashboard.
- The Receipts page displays all receipts for the current month. To view receipts from a different month, select the desired month from the month selector.
- To download receipts, click Download All to download all receipts for the selected month, or select a specific receipt and click Download.
- The selected receipt(s) will be downloaded immediately to your device.

5.3 Budget Management (New in v2.0.0)

The Budget section enables proactive financial planning by setting monthly spending limits per category, accessible via the dashboard shown in Figure 11.



Setting Budget Limits:

1. Navigate to **Budget** section
2. Click **'Set New Budget Limit'**
3. Select a **Category** from the dropdown menu
4. Enter your **Limit Amount** (e.g., 500.00)

5. The system automatically applies the budget to the current month and year, or to the next month if the Apply to Next Month checkbox is selected.
6. Click **'Save'**

Note: The system prevents duplicate budgets for the same category in the same month using database constraints.

Monitoring Budget Utilization:

The Budget Dashboard displays real-time tracking:

- **Category:** Name of the budget category
- **Limit:** Your maximum allowed spending
- **Spent:** Total amount logged for this category this month
- **Remaining:** Difference between limit and spent amount
- **% Used:** Visual progress bar showing budget consumption

Deleting Budget Limits:

- Click the **'Delete'** icon next to the budget entry
- Adjust the limit amount
- Click **'Save'**

5.4 Overview Section - Statistical Analysis

The Overview section provides comprehensive statistical analysis of your spending patterns, as highlighted in Figure 12.

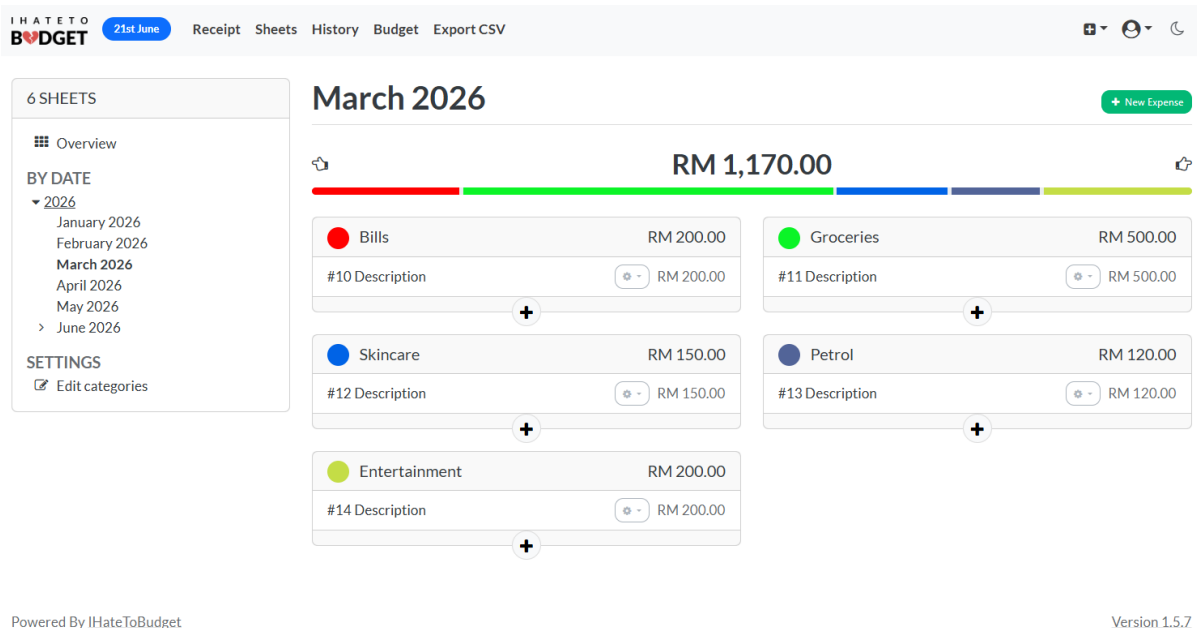


Figure 12: Overview Statistics of Expenses

Key Statistics

- **Total Spending:** Aggregated expenses for selected period

- Category Distribution: Visual breakdown by expense category
- Monthly Trends: Comparison of spending across months

Interactive Features:

- Switch between categories
- Select different time periods using the date range selector

5.5 History Section - Comprehensive Search & Filter

The History section provides access to all recorded expenses with advanced filtering capabilities, as seen in Figure 13.

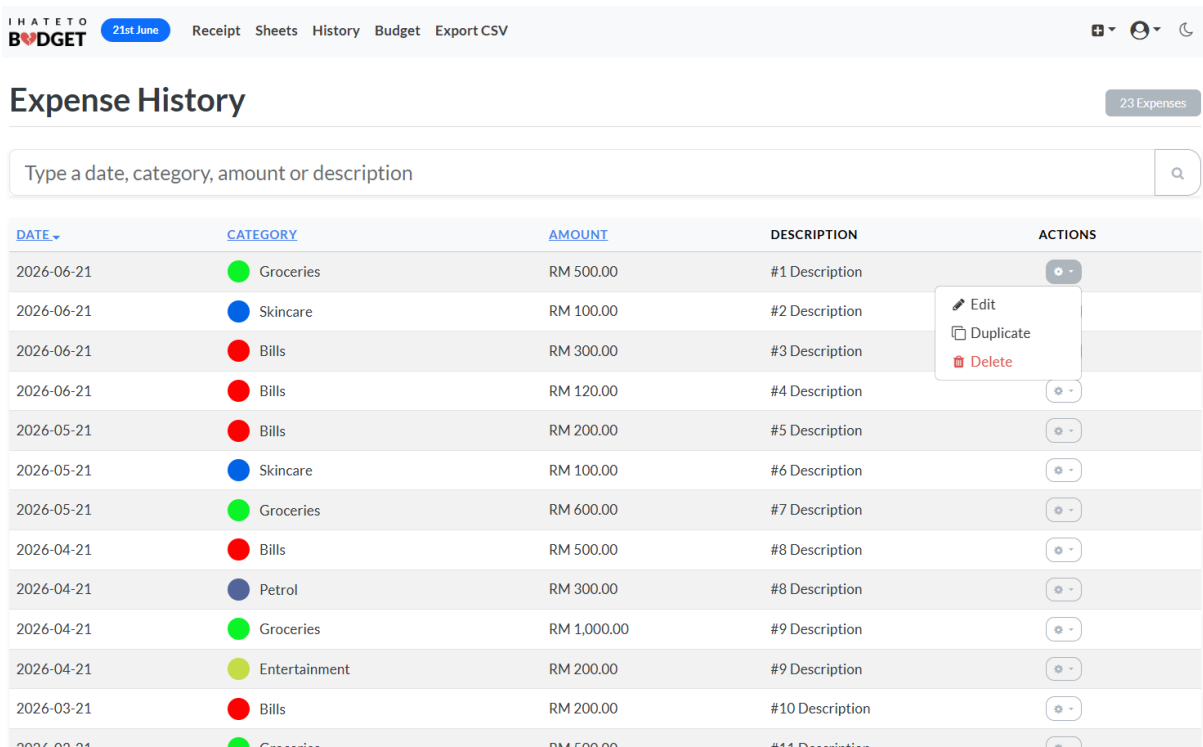


Figure 13: History View

Filtering Expenses

Use the following filters to locate specific expenses:

- Date Range: Filter by start and end dates
- Category: Select one or multiple categories
- Amount Range: Filter by minimum and maximum amounts
- Description Search: Full-text search in expense descriptions

5.6 Data Export (New in v2.0.0)

Export your financial data for external analysis, tax preparation, or backup purposes, as shown in Figure 14.

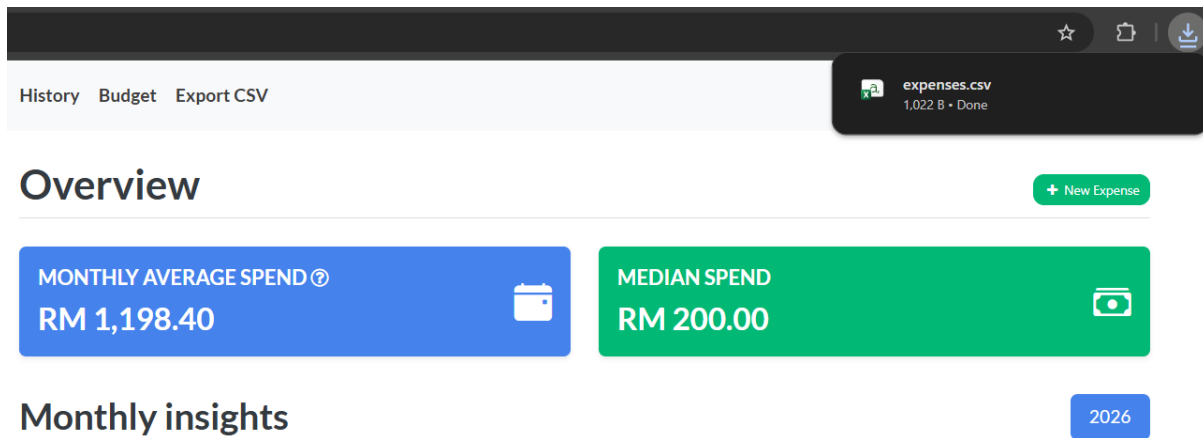


Figure 14: CSV Export

Exporting All Data:

1. Click 'Export CSV' in the top navigation bar
2. Your browser will automatically download a file named `ihatetobudget_export_YYYY-MM-DD.csv`
3. Open the file in Microsoft Excel, Google Sheets, or any spreadsheet application

Export Contents:

The CSV file includes:

- Category
- Description
- Amount

Security Note:

- Export is strictly filtered to your authenticated user account
- Other users cannot access your financial data

5.7 Interface Preferences (New in v2.0.0)

Dark Mode Toggle:

Users can toggle between light and dark modes to suit their environment, as demonstrated in Figure 15.

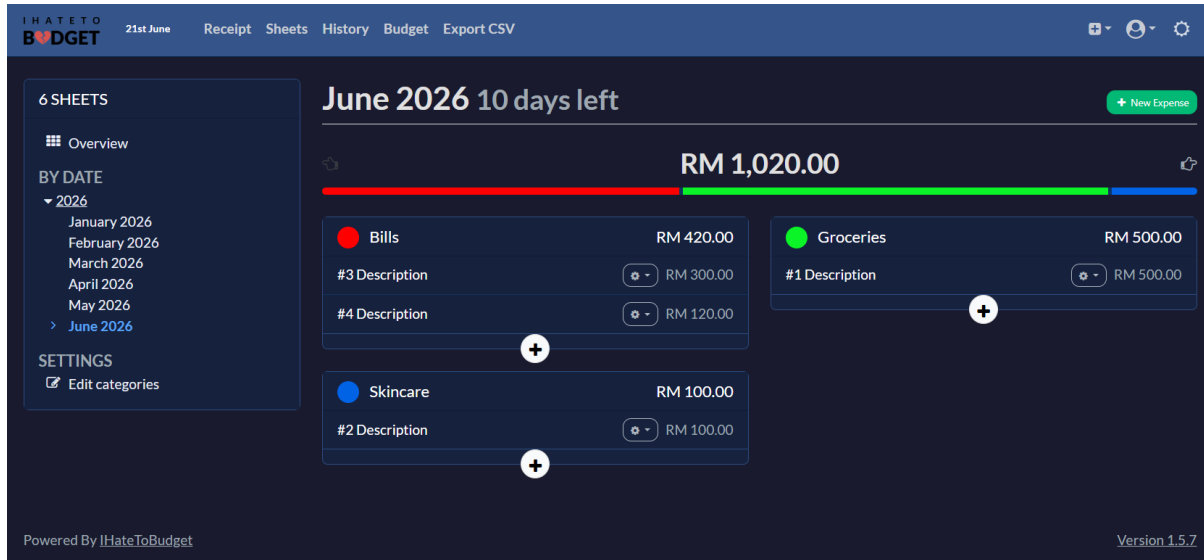


Figure 15: Dark Mode

- Locate the Toggle Theme button in the top navigation bar
- Click to instantly switch between Light Mode and Dark Mode
- Your preference is automatically saved in the browser's local storage
- The application will remember your choice on subsequent visits

6. Detailed User Guide

6.1 User Account Management

Accessing Account Settings

Click the user profile icon in the top-right corner and select 'Settings' to access account management options.

Changing Password

1. Navigate to Account Settings
2. Click 'Change Password'
3. Enter your current password
4. Enter and confirm your new password
5. Click 'Save' to confirm change

6.2 Data Export & Backup

Regular data backups are critical for data protection. The database file (db.sqlite3) should be backed up regularly:

```
cp db.sqlite3 db.sqlite3.backup.$(date +%Y%m%d)
```

This creates a timestamped backup of your database.

6.3 Managing Multiple Users

IHateToBudget supports household use with multiple user accounts. Each user maintains their own expense data. Note: Currently, data is shared at the household level, designed for small household groups.

Creating Additional User Accounts

Accessing Docker container to create user accounts:

```
docker-compose exec web python manage.py createsuperuser
```

Follow the prompts to enter username, email, and password.

6.4 Importing Historical Data

To migrate historical expense data from other applications:

6. Export data from source application in CSV format
7. Manually add categories in IHateToBudget matching source categories
8. Manually add each expense entry, or write a custom script to automate the import

7. Best Practices & Recommendations

7.1 Category Design Best Practices

Category Naming Conventions

Use clear, specific category names that reflect spending patterns:

✓ GOOD: 'Groceries', 'Public Transport', 'Entertainment', 'Utilities'

✗ POOR: 'Misc', 'Expenses', 'Money Out'

Optimal Number of Categories

Recommended: 8-15 categories. Too few categories obscure spending patterns; too many create unnecessary complexity. Example category structure:

Category	Examples
Essentials	Rent, Utilities, Insurance
Food	Groceries, Dining Out
Transportation	Transit, Fuel, Maintenance
Entertainment	Movies, Hobbies, Subscriptions

7.2 Data Entry Best Practices

Consistent data entry ensures accurate financial analysis:

- Enter expenses promptly: Record expenses on the same day to ensure accuracy
- Use descriptions: Add brief descriptions for context (e.g., 'Grocery - Tesco')
- Correct date entry: Use actual transaction date, not recording date
- Include receipts: Keep physical receipts for verification

7.3 Backup & Data Protection

Implement regular automated backups. Example backup script:

```
#!/bin/bash BACKUP_DIR="/backups/ihatetobudget" DATE=$(date +%Y%m%d_%H%M%S) cp db.sqlite3 "$BACKUP_DIR/db_$DATE.sqlite3" find $BACKUP_DIR -name "db_*.sqlite3" -mtime +30 -delete
```

Add to crontab to run daily: 0 2 * * * /path/to/backup.sh

7.4 Performance Optimization

For optimal application performance:

- Archive old data: Move historical data to separate storage if the database grows large

- Regular maintenance: Run database optimization periodically
- Monitor disk space: Ensure adequate storage for continued operation

8. Troubleshooting & Support

8.1 Common Issues & Solutions

Issue: Application does not start

Troubleshooting steps:

1. Verify Docker is running: `docker ps`
2. Check logs: `docker-compose logs`
3. Verify port 80 is available: `lsof -i :80`
4. Restart containers: `docker-compose restart`

Issue: Cannot access application on network

Possible causes and solutions:

- Firewall blocking: Check system and network firewall rules
- Incorrect IP address: Use hostname or correct server IP
- Port mapping error: Verify `docker-compose.yml` port configuration

Issue: Login credentials not accepted

Resolution steps:

1. Verify correct username/password case sensitivity
2. Check for database corruption: `docker-compose logs`
3. Reset user via `manage.py` if necessary

8.2 Database Recovery

If database becomes corrupted, restore from backup:

```
docker-compose down cp db.sqlite3.backup db.sqlite3 docker-  
compose up -d
```

This restores the application from the most recent backup.

8.3 Getting Help

For additional support:

- GitHub Repository: github.com/ImY1l/ihatetobudget
- Issues: Open a GitHub issue with detailed error information
- Docker Logs: Include full `docker-compose` logs output when reporting issues

9. Appendix

9.1 Frequently Asked Questions (FAQ)

The Frequently Asked Questions (FAQ) are provided in the following document:

<https://github.com/ImY1l/ihatetobudget/blob/517e68afb4c361c509cb1c975c7aafa4be590981/FAQ.pdf>

9.2 Update Procedures

To update IHateToBudget to the latest version:

1. Backup current database: `cp db.sqlite3 db.sqlite3.bak`
2. Stop containers: `docker-compose down -v`
3. Pull latest code: `git pull`
4. Start containers: `docker-compose up -d`
5. Verify application functionality

9.3 Glossary

Term	Definition
Category	User-defined classification for expense grouping (e.g., Groceries, Transport)
Docker	Container platform enabling consistent application deployment across systems
Django	Python web framework used for IHateToBudget backend
Sheet	Monthly expense entry view displaying all transactions for a given month
SQLite	Lightweight, file-based database system used for data storage

9.4 Technical Reference

API Endpoints (For Developer Reference)

The application provides RESTful API endpoints for data access and manipulation. Common endpoints include:

GET `/api/categories/` - Retrieve all categories

POST `/api/expenses/` - Create new expense entry

GET /api/statistics/ - Retrieve statistical data

Environment Variables

Configuration via environment variables:

```
DEBUG=False DJANGO_SECRET_KEY=your-secret-key ALLOWED_HOSTS=*
```

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